

Over 30% of our seas protected?

*Testing a government claim about marine protected areas
against EEA boundaries and EU reporting*

THE CLAIM UNDER REVIEW

***“Malta protects more than 30% of
its maritime zone...”***

Environment Minister Miriam Dalli, 2025 (as quoted by Amphora Media).

ERA: more than 35% of the Fisheries Management Zone.

VERDICT: MISLEADING

36% of the fisheries zone; 5.5% of the waters reported to the EU

TL;DR

Environment Minister Miriam Dalli said in 2025 that “**Malta protects more than 30% of its maritime zone**”; ERA says its marine Natura 2000 network covers “more than 35% of Malta’s Fisheries Management Zone”. International databases put Malta under 10%. We measured the protected area ourselves and divided it by each reference area in use.

- 1

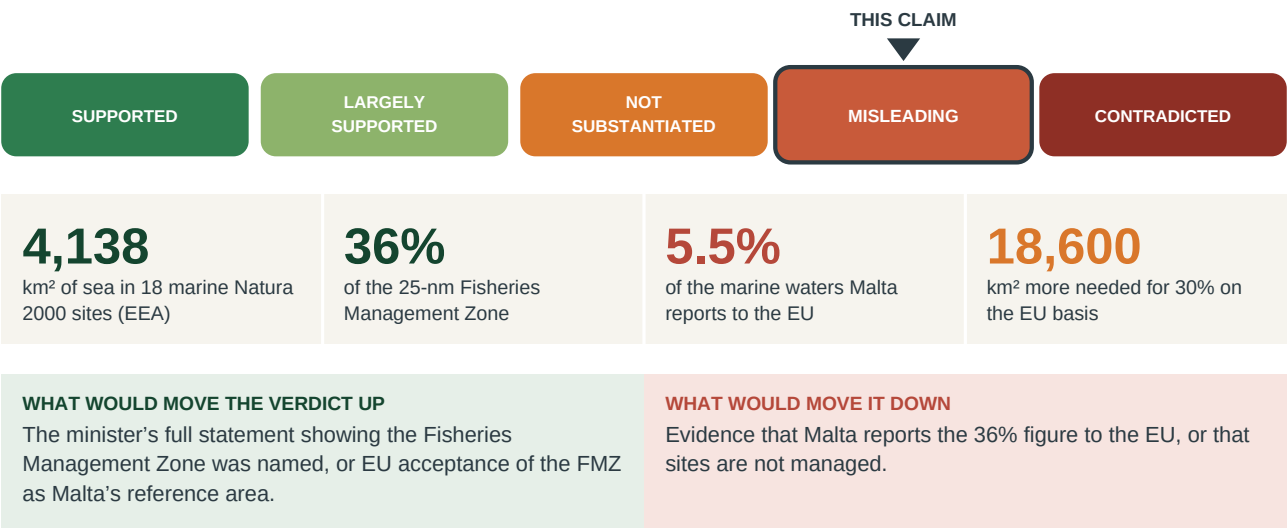
The protected area is as stated. EEA boundaries give 18 marine Natura 2000 sites covering 4,138 km² of sea once overlaps are counted once, matching ERA’s “over 4,100 km²”.
- 2

The percentage depends on what you divide by. 4,138 km² is 36% of the 25-nautical-mile Fisheries Management Zone, 7.8% of the exclusive economic zone as mapped internationally and 5.5% of the 75,715 km² of marine waters Malta reports to the EU.
- 3

ERA says which zone it means; the minister did not. “Maritime zone” suggests all of Malta’s waters. The figure Malta reports for the EU’s 30% target is 5.5%, one of the lowest in the EU; reaching 30% on that basis would need about 18,600 km² more.
- 4

Protected on paper. Natura 2000 designation allows fishing and other uses if species are kept in good condition; this check does not assess management.
- 5

Verdict: misleading (moderate confidence). Accurate for the Fisheries Management Zone, but presented without that qualifier it gives an inaccurate impression of Malta’s standing against the EU target. The minister’s words are known through a news report.



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1

The claim

What was said	Who	Access
“Malta protects more than 30% of its maritime zone, through Natura 2000 sites, scientific monitoring, and a €2 million conservation programme.”	Minister Miriam Dalli, 2025 [2]	Second-hand ♦
“Malta’s marine Natura 2000 network encompasses 18 sites and covers over 4100 km2, equivalent to more than 35% of Malta’s Fisheries Management Zone”	ERA [1]	Read in full
“designated over 35% of Malta’s waters as Marine Protected Areas” (2021)	ERA [2]	Second-hand ♦

Amphora Media published a fact-check of the same statements in August 2025 [2]. We repeated the measurement independently from the EEA boundaries.

2

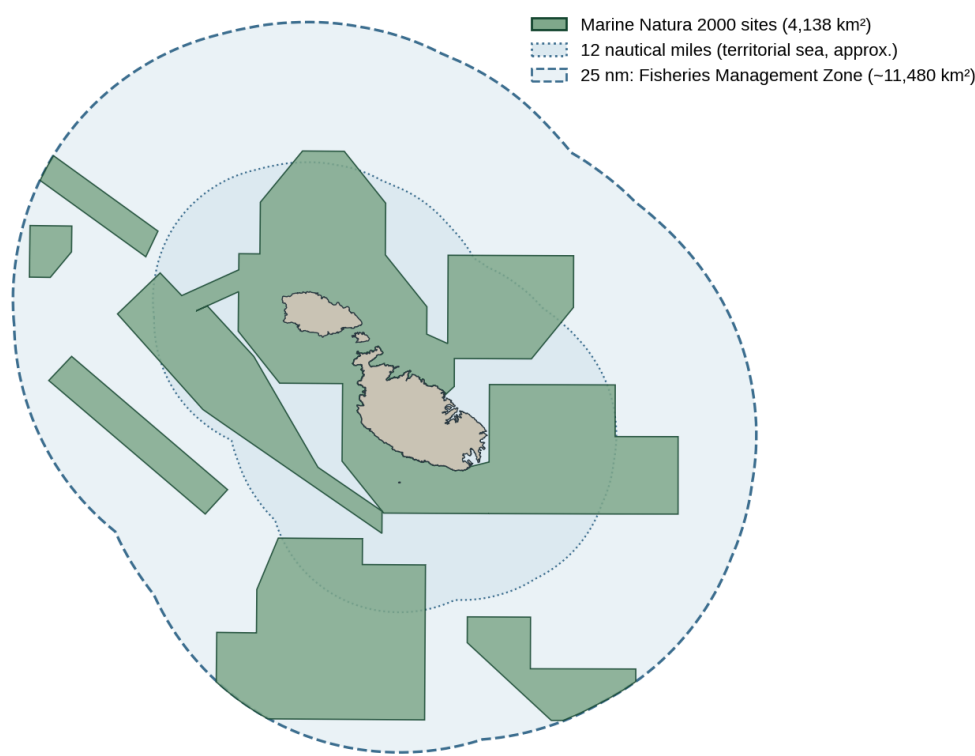
Method

Boundaries of all Maltese Natura 2000 sites from the EEA (2024 release) [3]; overlapping marine sites dissolved and land removed with OpenStreetMap coastlines; areas in UTM 33N. Reference areas: the Fisheries Management Zone as stated by the government (checked against a 25-nm buffer, about 11,650 km²), the exclusive economic zone used by Protected Planet and Marine Regions, and the area reported to the EU [4]. Scripts: *tools/cc-051-report/*.

3

What the data show

Malta's marine protected sites and the zones used to measure them



The area Malta reports to the EU (about 75,700 km², up to 200 nm) extends far beyond this frame. Sources: EEA Natura 2000 (2024); coastline © OpenStreetMap contributors.

Figure 1. The 18 marine sites, the 12-nm territorial sea and the 25-nm Fisheries Management Zone.

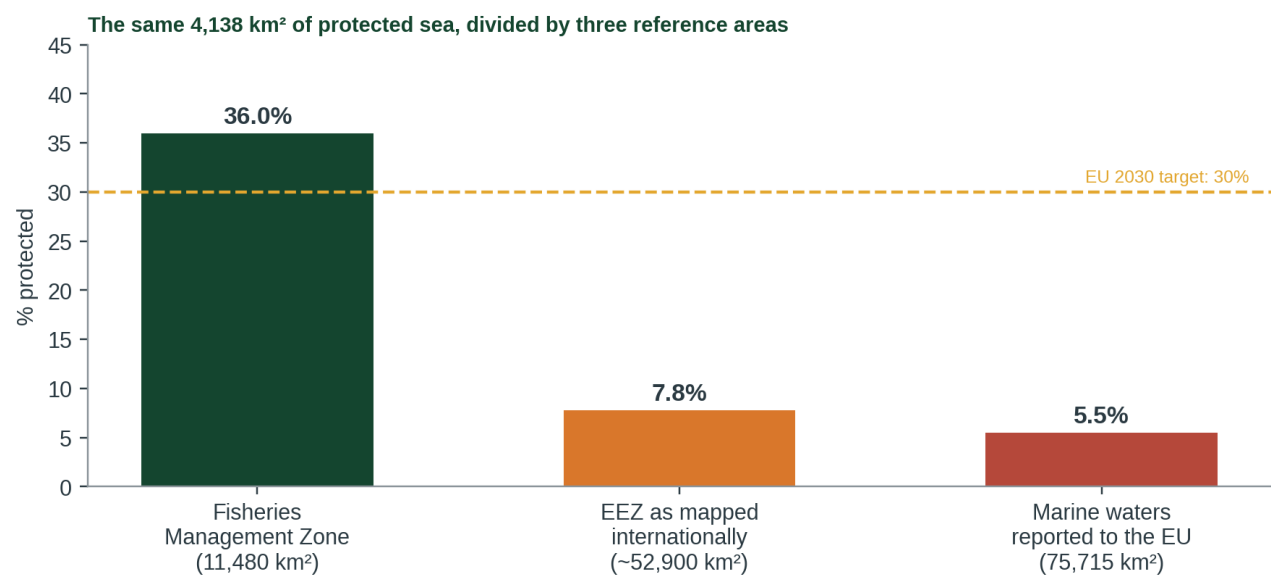


Figure 2. One protected area, three percentages.

Measure	Value	Source	Grade
Protected sea, 18 sites (overlaps once)	4,138 km²	EEA [3]; ERA: over 4,100 [1]	C
Share of Fisheries Management Zone (11,480 km²)	36.0%	calculated	C

Measure	Value	Source	Grade
Share of EEZ as mapped internationally (~52,900 km²)	7.8%	calculated; Protected Planet 7.83%	C
Share of marine waters reported to the EU (75,715 km²)	5.5%	calculated; BISE 5.5% [4]	C
Extra area for 30% on the EU basis	~18,600 km²	calculated	C

4 Where the evidence points different ways

Q1 Which area is the right one?	DEPENDS ON THE PURPOSE
EVIDENCE FOR THE CLAIM'S IMPRESSION Malta manages the FMZ and its national biodiversity target is written for it; a University of Malta geologist told Amphora the FMZ reflects Malta's practical mandate [2].	EVIDENCE AGAINST For EU accounting Malta itself reports 75,715 km², and the EU's 30% target is tracked on that basis [2, 4]. No other Mediterranean EU state was found using a fisheries zone as the denominator [2].
WHY THEY DIFFER, AND WHAT IT MEANS HERE For this claim: both percentages are arithmetic; only one is how Malta is measured against the EU target.	

Q2 Does “maritime zone” tell the reader which?	NO
EVIDENCE FOR THE CLAIM'S IMPRESSION ERA's own page names the Fisheries Management Zone [1].	EVIDENCE AGAINST The minister's statement does not, and “maritime zone” reads as all of Malta's waters.
WHY THEY DIFFER, AND WHAT IT MEANS HERE For this claim: dropping the qualifier is what makes it misleading.	

5 Testing the claim

Sub-claim	What the evidence shows	Rating
A. 18 marine sites, over 4,100 km²	4,138 km² [3].	SUPPORTED
B. Over 35% of the Fisheries Management Zone	36.0%.	SUPPORTED
C. Over 30% of Malta's “maritime zone” / waters	5.5% of the waters reported to the EU.	MISLEADING

6 Verdict and requests for evidence

VERDICT MISLEADING True for the Fisheries Management Zone; presented as Malta's seas it overstates protection about sixfold. Confidence: moderate.
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Why. The arithmetic behind “over 30%” is correct for one reference area. Stated as a share of Malta’s “maritime zone” or “waters” without naming that area, it gives the impression that Malta has met the EU’s 30% target, while on the basis Malta itself reports to the EU the coverage is 5.5%. Confidence is moderate because the minister’s words are known through a news report.

Evidence we are asking for

- ☐ The minister’s statement in full, with event and date.
- ☐ Which reference area Malta will use to report against the EU 2030 target.
- ☐ Management plans and monitoring results for the offshore sites.

7 Limitations

- Areas computed in UTM 33N with OSM coastlines; small differences from official GIS are expected.
- The EEZ and EU-reported areas are as published, not recomputed from boundary files.
- This check covers designation, not the effectiveness of protection.

References

- [1] Environment and Resources Authority. Marine Protected Areas (topic page); read 4 Oct 2026.
<https://era.org.mt/topic/marine-protected-areas-2/>
- [2] Amphora Media (Aug 2025). FATTI: Does Malta protect about one-third of its seas? ☐ for quoted statements.
<https://www.amphora.media/2025/08/fatti-malta-protect-sea-marine-environment>
- [3] European Environment Agency. Natura 2000 sites, 2024 release; queried 4 Oct 2026.
<https://bio.discomap.eea.europa.eu/arcgis/rest/services/ProtectedSites/Natura2000Sites/MapServer>
- [4] Biodiversity Information System for Europe. Malta country page. <https://biodiversity.europa.eu/countries/malta>
- [5] MiŻien. Data and calculations: [data/cc-051/](#); [tools/cc-051-report/](#).

Appendix A: series standards and verdict scale

Every investigation in this series follows the same rules so that verdicts are comparable and challengeable.

Verdict	Meaning
SUPPORTED	Evidence consistently backs the claim as stated.
LARGELY SUPPORTED	Backed by the evidence, with minor caveats that do not change the substance.
NOT SUBSTANTIATED	Stated more strongly than the evidence offered or available allows. May be true in some conditions but has not been shown.
MISLEADING	Omits material facts so that the overall impression is inaccurate, even if individual statements are defensible.
CONTRADICTED	The available evidence points against the claim.

Confidence

High: multiple independent lines of evidence agree. **Moderate:** evidence is relevant but incomplete or indirect. **Low:** evidence is thin, second-hand or conflicting.

Evidence grades

A experiment · B observational study with a control or gradient · C review, guidance or official statistics · D assertion or anecdote. ♦ marks a source known only second-hand.

Standards

- **Quote the speaker, not the headline**, with outlet and date, and link the original where possible.
- **Separate the claim from the evidence offered for it**, and say who made which statement.
- **Grade the evidence** and show differing views side by side where the evidence is unsettled.
- **State what we could not access or verify**, and what would change the verdict either way.
- **Ask for the missing evidence** in specific, answerable requests.
- **Offer a right of reply** before wider circulation and append responses.
- **Correct errors openly** with a version number and change log.
- **Whistle-blow only on evidence:** a verdict of *Misleading* or *Contradicted* requires documents or data that can be shown, not inference.
- **Check every side.** Government, opposition, NGOs and developers are held to the same standard.

Appendix B: revision log

Version	Date	Change
1.0	4 Oct 2026	First issue. Right of reply to the Environment Ministry and ERA not yet sent.